

Editorial *Style Guide.*

The visual language of Recollection Wisconsin's redesigned website.
Color, typography, components, and interaction patterns for handoff and continuity.

CAPSTONE PROJECT / LEAH GOLDBLUM / LIS 640 / UW-MADISON ISCHOOL / SPRING 2026

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Five colors. One system.

Each color maps to an audience pathway. This creates visual wayfinding so users always know where they are in the site. All combinations meet or exceed WCAG AA contrast on white.

	Archival Blue #1e3a5f  Researchers, hero banners, footer, genealogist pathway. AAA 10.7:1
	Rustic Orange #b85c38  Partners, primary CTAs, Main Street Mondays, primary actions. AA 4.5:1
	Sage Green #5a7d5e  Educators, Quick Find, teaching resources, success states. AA 4.6:1
	Deep Teal #2c6e7f  About, Explore, learn more actions, info callouts. AA 5.1:1
	Heritage Gold #a87a2e  Recognition only: awards, honors, hero eyebrow accents. AA 4.6:1

■ GOLD USAGE RULE

Heritage Gold is reserved for recognition and honors only: the Family Tree Magazine award callout, the fee-free badge, and hero eyebrow accents. It should never be used as a primary CTA color or an audience pathway identifier. Using it elsewhere dilutes its meaning as a recognition signal.

Three faces. Clear *hierarchy*.

DM Serif Display for headings, Source Serif 4 for body, JetBrains Mono for labels and UI elements. Minimum body copy: 14px. Minimum eyebrow: 11px. Body line height: 1.7 for dyslexia-friendly reading.

DM Serif Display

Headings, card titles, section headers, hero text.

Discover Wisconsin

Source Serif 4

Body copy, descriptions, long-form reading text.

Over 600,000 stories from Wisconsin libraries, archives, and museums.

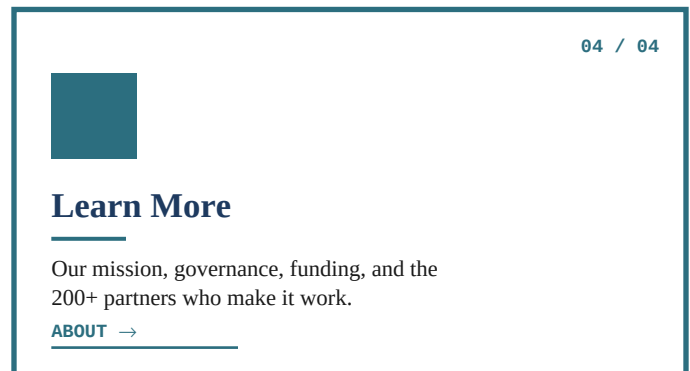
JetBrains Mono

Eyebrows, labels, section numbers, CTAs, metadata badges.

§ 01 / FOR EDUCATORS

The editorial card.

Every interactive card in the system follows this pattern: sharp 2px border in an accent color, eyebrow label, display serif title, 2px colored rule, body description, and a persistent CTA label with arrow at the bottom. Cards lift and cast a hard-edge drop shadow on hover.



■ HOVER BEHAVIOR

On hover, the card translates -3px horizontally and vertically, and a 6×6 hard-edge drop shadow appears in the accent color. The background transitions to the accent-light tint. The CTA arrow shifts +4px right. All transitions are 200ms ease. Never use blur shadows — they're not part of this system.

How the system *behaves*.

Seven rules governing motion, feedback, and interactive feedback across the site. Applied consistently, they make every interaction feel like part of the same system.

§ 01 Hover lift

All colored cards lift up-left 3px and cast a 6px hard-edge drop shadow in the accent color on hover. Never use blur shadows.

§ 02 Always-visible CTAs

Every interactive card shows its CTA label at all times. Arrow shifts 4px right on hover. CTAs never appear only on hover.

§ 03 Section numbering

Every major section opens with a monospace eyebrow in format: § 01 / Label. Numbers are sequential within a page, not sitewide.

§ 04 Italic color accents

Display headings use italic for a single emphasized word in an accent color. Never italicize more than one word per headline.

§ 05 Sharp edges

All borders are exactly 2px. All corners are 0px radius. Icon containers are squares, not rounded squares.

§ 06 Grain texture

Dark navy heroes and select light sections use a subtle SVG noise overlay at ~4% opacity. Never on pure body content.

§ 07 Audience colors

Each audience pathway owns a color: Sage for Educators, Navy for Genealogists, Warm for Partners, Teal for About/Explore.

Consistent *rhythm*.

The spacing scale follows an 8-point grid with Tailwind utility class names. Values are given for both mobile and desktop so you can reference them when extending the system.

Padding – cards	p-6 (24px) mobile → p-8 or p-10 (32-40px) on md+ screens
Padding – sections	py-14 (56px) mobile → py-20 (80px) on md+ screens
Margins – after h1	mb-5 to mb-6 (20-24px)
Margins – after h2	mb-4 to mb-5 (16-20px)
Grid gaps	gap-5 (20px) mobile → gap-6 or gap-8 (24-32px) on md+ screens
Line height – body	1.7 (generous, dyslexia-friendly)
Line height – display	1.0 to 1.05 (tight for impact)
Letter spacing – eyebrows	0.25em (wide, helps monospace legibility)

■ RESPONSIVE BREAKPOINTS

Breakpoint	Width	Tailwind	Typical device
Mobile	0-639px	(default)	iPhone SE through standard phone portrait
SM	640-767px	sm:	Large phone landscape, small tablet portrait
MD	768-1023px	md:	iPad portrait, small laptop
LG	1024-1279px	lg:	iPad landscape, standard laptop
XL	1280px+	xl:	Desktop monitor, large laptop

Built for everyone.

The site meets WCAG 2.1 Level AA and includes several Level AAA features. Every feature listed below is working in production — not aspirational.

2.1.1 Keyboard	Every interactive element is reachable by Tab and operable by Enter/Space. No keyboard traps.
2.4.1 Bypass Blocks	Skip-to-main-content link appears when keyboard users tab from page load. Jumps past the header.
2.4.7 Focus Visible	Global 2px gold outline ring on any focused element. Works on every button, link, input, and custom widget.
1.3.1 Info & Relations	Semantic HTML throughout. One h1 per page. Logical heading hierarchy. Proper list markup.
1.1.1 Non-text Content	All images have alt text. Decorative elements marked aria-hidden. SVG map regions have ARIA labels.
1.4.3 Contrast	All color combinations meet WCAG AA 4.5:1 minimum. Dark navy heroes meet AAA 10.7:1.
3.3.2 Labels	Every form input has an associated via htmlFor/id. Screen readers announce labels on focus.
4.1.2 Name Role Value	Interactive elements have accessible names. Dropdown buttons include aria-expanded and aria-haspopup.
2.3.3 Reduced Motion	Global prefers-reduced-motion support. Count-up animations disabled. Transitions reduced to 0.01ms.
2.5.5 Target Size	Touch targets enforced to 44×44 minimum on screens under 768px via CSS media query.

Four colors. Four *journeys*.

Each audience pathway is assigned a color that stays consistent from the home page through every subpage. Users learn 'my color' and use it as a wayfinding cue.

Educators

SAGE GREEN

Teachers, K-12 through post-secondary. Primary use case: finding classroom-ready primary sources fast.

Genealogists

ARCHIVAL BLUE

Family history researchers, amateur and professional. Primary use case: surname + place searches across county records.

Partners

RUSTIC ORANGE

Libraries, museums, historical societies. Primary use case: understanding Hosting vs Harvesting, then starting intake.

About/Explore

DEEP TEAL

Anyone curious about RW as an organization, or who wants to browse collections without a specific goal.

The *team* and the thinking.

Designer & Developer

Leah Goldblum, UX Researcher and Designer. M.S. Information Science candidate, UW-Madison iSchool (May 2026). Capstone project for LIS 640.

Clients

Kristen Whitson, Program Manager, Recollection Wisconsin.

Andi Coffin, Communications & Consortia Manager, Recollection Wisconsin / WiLS.

Research Foundation

Stakeholder interviews with Kristen and Andi (January-March 2026). Audience analysis across four primary personas: educators, genealogists, partners, general public. Content audit of the existing recollectionwisconsin.org site. Competitive analysis against Digital Public Library of America (DPLA), New York Heritage, and Calisphere.

Design System References

Typography inspired by The Markup, The New York Times Magazine, and Pentagram's editorial work. Grain texture technique adapted from modern editorial websites. Color palette drawn from the Wisconsin landscape: archival blue (Lake Mendota at dusk), rustic orange (brick storefronts), sage green (dairy pastures), deep teal (Apostle Islands shoreline), heritage gold (autumn oak leaves).

Accessibility Standards

WCAG 2.1 Level AA compliance verified. Level AAA features include prefers-reduced-motion support, touch target size enforcement, and enhanced color contrast on dark hero banners (10.7:1). Tested with keyboard navigation and screen reader compatibility in mind.

How to Use This Document

This PDF is the printable companion to the live [/style-guide](#) route in the RW website. Share with stakeholders, reference during future design updates, and use as a baseline for any new components added to the system. For live interactive examples, see the in-site style guide.